

TreeAction CIC UK

Grey Water in the Garden: How to Use It Safely for Trees and Plants

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During dry spells, gardeners often look for ways to keep their plants healthy while saving precious mains water. One option is grey water — lightly used household water that can be reused outdoors. When handled correctly, grey water can support trees and shrubs, reduce water waste, and help gardens stay resilient in hot weather. This guide explains what grey water is, when it's safe to use, which plants benefit most, and which ones to avoid.

What Is Grey Water?

Grey water is the wastewater that comes from:

Showers

Baths

Bathroom sinks

Washing machines (when using mild detergents)

It does not include water from toilets or kitchen sinks.

According to the Royal Horticultural Society (RHS):

“Grey water should only be stored for up to 24 hours because of bacterial growth.”

Source: RHS – What is grey water? Expert advice on using grey water in gardens

<https://www.rhs.org.uk/soil-composts-mulches/grey-water> (rhs.org.uk in Bing)

This means grey water is best used fresh, not stored for long periods.

When Can Grey Water Be Used Safely?

Grey water is most useful during:

Drought

Hosepipe bans

Periods of low rainfall

It is safe to use when:

It comes from mild household sources

It does not contain bleach, disinfectants, or harsh chemicals

It is applied to the soil, not the leaves

It is used within 24 hours

The Woodland Trust also reminds gardeners that rainwater is always the safest choice, especially for edible plants.

Source: Woodland Trust – Environmentally-friendly gardening tips

**<https://www.woodlandtrust.org.uk/blog/2020/04/environmentally-friendly-gardening/>
(woodlandtrust.org.uk in Bing)**

Which Trees and Plants Can Handle Grey Water?

Some plants are naturally more tolerant of the salts and soaps found in grey water.

According to Greywater Action, many fruit trees can thrive on grey water as long as the detergents used are mild and low in salts.

Source: Greywater Action – Choosing and irrigating plants with greywater

**<https://greywateraction.org/choosing-and-irrigating-plants-with-greywater/>
(greywateraction.org in Bing)**

Good candidates include:

Apple trees

Pear trees

Fig trees

Olive trees

Many drought-tolerant native species

The Forestry Commission's resource Looking after trees and woodland during dry weather also highlights that drought-tolerant species cope better with irregular watering and mild impurities.

Source: <https://www.gov.uk/guidance/looking-after-trees-and-woodland-during-dry-weather> (gov.uk in Bing)

Plants and Trees to Avoid

Some species are salt-sensitive and may be harmed by grey water, especially if detergents contain sodium.

Avoid using grey water on:

Avocado

Lemon and other citrus

Scotch pine

Blueberries

Ferns

Most houseplants

These plants can suffer from leaf burn, root damage, or long-term soil imbalance.

How to Use Grey Water Responsibly

Use grey water from safe sources (showers, baths, bathroom sinks).

Avoid dishwater (contains salts, grease, food particles).

Apply to the soil, not the foliage.

Rotate where you water to prevent salt build-up.

Use within 24 hours.

Choose salt-tolerant species such as fruit trees and drought-tolerant shrubs.

References

RHS – <https://www.rhs.org.uk/soil-composts-mulches/grey-water> (rhs.org.uk in Bing)

Woodland Trust – <https://www.woodlandtrust.org.uk/blog/2020/04/environmentally-friendly-gardening/> (woodlandtrust.org.uk in Bing)

Greywater Action – <https://greywateraction.org/choosing-and-irrigating-plants-with-greywater/> (greywateraction.org in Bing)

Forestry Commission – <https://www.gov.uk/guidance/looking-after-trees-and-woodland-during-dry-weather> (gov.uk in Bing)